Significantly, India has never received a credible explanation for the change in China's stance nor convincing reasons for massing of troops in the border areas. It is a different matter that our own forces have responded appropriately and held their own in challenging circumstances. The issue before us is what the Chinese posture signals, how it evolves and what implications it may have for the future of our ties.

Even before 2020, the India–China relationship witnessed decisions and events that reflected the duality of coexistence and competition. We saw trade grow dramatically, though its one-sided nature made it increasingly controversial. In sectors like power and telecommunications, Chinese companies successfully obtained access to India and built impressive market shares. The number of Indian students in China grew, as indeed did Indian tourists who visited there.

In the global arena, India and China made common cause on some developmental and economic issues, notably in climate change (UNFCCC) and trade (WTO). Our membership of plurilateral groups like BRICS and RIC was also a meeting point.

Yet, when it came to interests and aspirations, many of the divergences were also apparent. China started the practice of issuing stapled visas for residents of Jammu & Kashmir and Arunachal Pradesh. Their reluctance to deal with India's military command in the northern sector led to the freezing of exchanges for some time. Water-marking of Chinese passports covered Indian provinces within their boundaries in an attempt to assert claims. Border area frictions continued to grow as China's infrastructure steadily advanced.

In India, these multiple realities naturally fed an increasingly animated debate. There was a powerful lobby that not only advocated deepening ties but even exempting China from the limited security scrutiny that was then in place. To some, such expanded cooperation was a compensation for the improvement in India–US ties that was then taking place. This perhaps was buttressed by a natural proclivity to build on a Nehruvian outlook to China, as much as to the world. Discussions on the boundary question were, therefore, publicly projected far more positively than the actual progress justified. And as trade expanded, active proponents in its favour came into their own.

Yet, the systemic response remained much more cognizant of hard realities, seeking to put in place filters of various kinds, pushing back on